



MERIDITH KOHUT FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

A search for drugs in a cell at the Cook County jail in Chicago, which has been infiltrated by powerful synthetic substances.

A Lifeline for Inmates Turns Deadly

By AZAM AHMED and MATT RICHTEL

The body lay slumped on the jail floor, curled around a metal toilet.

Investigators found no evidence of homicide, just a few scraps of rolled-up paper, singed and scattered on the floor like scorched confetti.

THE NEW DRUG WAR
Beyond Pills and Needles

For months, inmates had been falling ill at the Cook County jail in Chicago. Officials said they had heard rumors that extremely toxic drugs were infiltrating the facility, delivered on something so ordinary that it seemed impossible to stop.

Then the body appeared, and “something clicked,” said Justin Wilks, the head investi-

Paper Saturated With Drugs Is Sneaking Into Prisons

gator at the jail.

The paper itself must be the culprit — and it was deadly.

More overdoses soon followed. The next month, in February 2023, another inmate died from smoking paper laced with mysterious new drugs. In April, one more.

“People were dying so fast,” Mr. Wilks said. But when officials at the jail told their law enforcement colleagues about it, they said, some found it hard to believe.

By year’s end, at least six people had died of overdoses, putting the jail at the vanguard of a new kind of drug war, one in

which extraordinarily powerful drugs can be invented faster than the authorities can identify them.

And where something as ubiquitous as paper can become lethal.

Today, fringe chemists are ushering in a total transformation of the illicit drug market. Operating from clandestine labs, they are churning out a dizzying array of synthetic drugs — not only fentanyl, but also hazardous new tranquilizers, stimulants and complex cannabinoids. Sometimes, several unknown drugs appear on the streets in a single month. Many are so new they are not even illegal yet.

Nearly all of them are harder to trace than conventional drugs, less expensive to produce, much more potent and far deadlier, according to scientists and law enforcement

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NEWS ANALYSIS

U.S. and Israel Differ On Defining Victory

More Pain at Pump Recasts Midterms

By LISA LERER

As they entered this midterm year, many Democratic and Republican politicians agreed on one central campaign theme. This would be an election about affordability, with both parties battling over who best addressed the high costs of housing, child care, groceries, health care, utilities and gas.

But President Trump’s decision to attack Iran has complicated the equation, and left Republicans pushing a different message: Please ignore the price at the pump.

From Congress to the campaign trail, Republican leaders, elected officials and candidates are promising that the increase in energy prices will be temporary, asking voters to bear short-term pain to their pocketbooks for what they promise will be long-term gains for their country.

“What we’re paying at the gas pump is a small price to pay in order to save millions of lives in the future,” Representative Buddy Carter, who is running for the Republican nomination for Senate in Georgia, where gas prices have increased nearly 40 percent over the past month, said in an interview on conservative television. “This is a painful experience at the pump right now, but that is going to stabilize.”

It’s a strategy that echoes that of the Biden administration, whose top officials promised the rise in inflation after the Covid-19 pandemic would be “transitory” and then spent years blaming culprits from President Vladimir V. Putin of Russia to the Federal Reserve for continued high prices.

“I thought there was a chance it

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Worries Over Oil vs. Middle East Fears

By STEVEN ERLANGER

BERLIN — Israel launched a major attack on an Iranian gas field last week, prompting retaliation against Gulf states, a threat to global energy supplies and a surge in fuel prices. President Trump first insisted the United States “knew nothing about” the strike, but later backtracked and said he warned Israel against attacking the complex.

His attempt to distance his administration from the strike underscored the diverging aims of the United States and Israel as their war against Iran grinds on.

As a superpower with global responsibilities, the United States cares deeply about global energy supplies and the safety of its Persian Gulf allies. And with crucial midterm elections later this year, the Trump administration cares deeply about the rising price of gasoline in the United States.

But as a regional power, Israel has different strategic aims and more narrow concerns, analysts and former officials say. Israel has its own natural gas; little dependency on the Strait of Hormuz, where Iran has a chokehold on the transport of fuel; and no responsibility for the free flow of global trade. The stakes for Israel are higher than for the United States; it sees Iran, sworn to the destruction of Israel, as a clear danger, from its nuclear program and especially from its ballistic missiles.

Aaron David Miller, a former U.S. Middle East negotiator now at the Carnegie Endowment, said: “We are a global power and they are a regional one. So their threat assessments create a

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TARGET Iran said an attack was launched on a nuclear facility, and the U.S. and Israel gave mixed signals about the war’s direction. *PAGE 14*

MILITARY OPTIONS There are several ways the United States could try to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, all of which carry risks. *PAGE 12*

In ICE Lockup And Pregnant: ‘I Was Scared’

This article is by *Caroline Kitchener, Charo Henriquez and Hamed Aleaziz.*

WASHINGTON — Candy Castillo Collantes was six months pregnant when she stepped inside the giant tent where she would live for the next 47 days.

Her enclosure at the South Texas detention center held dozens of bunk beds, she said, with one tiny slit for a window. Women waited late into the night for their husbands and children. When Ms. Castillo Collantes experienced vaginal bleeding and asked for medical care at the facility, she and her lawyer said, she was offered only water, prenatal vitamins and a temperature check.

“It’s not a center that we know has a doctor,” Ms. Castillo Collantes, a 38-year-old Venezuelan who obtained temporary legal status under the Biden administration, said in an interview from the facility in late February. “The people here can’t tell you that everything is fine.”

Ms. Castillo Collantes had heard from other detainees about a woman who had gone into labor at their detention center months earlier.

She was terrified that she could be next.

Pregnant women who have been swept up in President Trump’s immigration crackdown have been held in detention center

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KELLY MARSHALL FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Bright and Beautiful Recipes From Africa and the Diaspora
From robust stews to meaty mains and vegetable dishes, welcome spring to your table. *Cooking.*

Confronting Chavez’s Legacy Across the Nation

By RICHARD FAUSSET

In Albuquerque, motorists drive across the historic Babelas neighborhood on Avenida Cesar Chavez. Where the avenue meets Broadway, they can pay their respects to the labor hero at the Cesar Chavez memorial. On the southeast side of town, children play after school at the Cesar Chavez Community Center.

All of these places may be soon renamed, along with the hundreds of other streets, schools and institutions across the United States

Abuse Claims Change Labor Hero’s Status

that had honored Mr. Chavez, one of the most revered figures in the Latino rights movement, as a founder of the United Farm Workers union.

The revelation last week that Mr. Chavez, who died in 1993, groomed and sexually abused girls has raised the likelihood that his name will soon be stripped

from places of public prominence.

In some cases, the process has begun. Last week in a number of cities, marches to honor Mr. Chavez were canceled. California lawmakers announced on Thursday that they intended to change the name of Cesar Chavez Day to Farmworkers Day. The University of California, Davis, said that it had removed Mr. Chavez’s name from a youth leadership conference it has run for more than 20 years.

The scraping away of the

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ROBERT S. MUELLER III, 1944-2026

Remade F.B.I. After Sept. 11 And Led Trump Investigation

By TIM WEINER

Robert S. Mueller III, who led the Federal Bureau of Investigation for 12 tumultuous years, brought politically explosive indictments as a special counsel examining Russia’s attack on the 2016 presidential election, and then concluded that he could neither absolve nor accuse President Trump of a crime, died on Friday. He was 81.

His family confirmed the death in a statement but did not say where he died or give the cause.

Mr. Trump remained unforgiving of Mr. Mueller’s investigation even after Mr. Mueller’s death. On learning of it on Saturday, he posted on Truth Social: “Good, I’m glad he’s dead. He can no longer hurt innocent people!”

A button-down, lockjawed, rock-ribbed exemplar of a vanishing caste, the liberal Republican, Mr. Mueller became the F.B.I. director just a week before the terrorist attacks of Sept. 11, 2001.

He went on to impose the most significant structural and cultural changes in the history of the F.B.I., seeking to transform the bureau into a 21st-century intelligence service that could protect both national security and civil liberties. And his counterterrorism agents were the first to blow the whistle



ERIN SCHAFF/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Robert S. Mueller III became a target of President Trump.

on abuses at the secret prisons that the C.I.A. had established after 9/11 to detain, interrogate and, in some cases, torture terrorism suspects.

But he may be best remembered for what he did after he left the F.B.I., when he was summoned to investigate a sitting president.

The Justice Department named Mr. Mueller special counsel on May 17, 2017, eight days after Mr. Trump dismissed the F.B.I. director, James B. Comey, who was investigating the interactions between the Trump campaign and a Russian covert operation to help

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INTERNATIONAL 4-15

The Castro on Instagram

Sandro Castro, a grandson of Fidel Castro, has drawn followers and scrutiny for his satirical posts in which he flaunts a life of luxury. *PAGE 4*

Jailed by an Autocrat

Maria Kalesnikava is campaigning for the West to engage with the regime in Belarus that imprisoned her. *PAGE 8*

NATIONAL 16-26

A Win for the Press

Reversing reporter restrictions at the Pentagon cut deeper than left-versus-right politics. News Analysis. *PAGE 19*



ARTS & LEISURE

Reinvention Plays a Role

At 67, the actress Michelle Pfeiffer has two new TV shows, and an evolving attitude about her work. *PAGE 8*

The Legend of Lithgow

The actor, who has played hundreds of roles, returns to Broadway as Roald Dahl in the play “Giant.” *PAGE 4*

METROPOLITAN

N.Y.P.D. Shield No. 13558

This badge, passed down through generations of police officers in New York City, has deflected a bullet. The men who have worn it have decades of history to share. *PAGE 8*

The Golden Corral Glimmers

Two generations of one family have owned this popular buffet restaurant in the Bronx, trying to change with the times while also staying true to the borough. *PAGE 7*

SUNDAY OPINION

Phil Klay

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SPECIAL SECTION

Baseball Preview

New rules and new players have re-energized Major League Baseball, but the specter of a lockout is looming.

SUNDAY BUSINESS

The \$500 Million Mystery Will

A seven-page document, mailed by an elusive figure, has set off a court battle over the estate of Tony Hsieh, the former chief executive of Zappos. *PAGE 6*

SUNDAY STYLES

A Vibrant Holiday Arrives

Muslim businesses around New York City prepared for Eid al-Fitr, the end of the holy month of Ramadan. *PAGE 12*

